



BURIEN BEST CARE HOME

Your Family Guide to Care

What to Know, What to Ask, and How to Choose the Right Home

Prepared by Burien Best Care Home

burienbestcarehome.com | 253.678.7089

A Letter to Your Family

Dear Family,

If you are reading this, you are probably in the middle of one of the hardest decisions you will ever make. We want you to know: the fact that you are researching, asking questions, and looking for the right place means you are already doing right by your parent.

This guide is designed to give you real, practical information. Whether you choose our home or another, we want you to feel confident in your decision. You deserve that. Your parent deserves that.

Choosing care for someone you love is deeply personal. There is no one right answer and no perfect timeline. What matters is that you are showing up, doing the research, and making the best decision you can with the information you have. That is enough.

We put this guide together because we have been on the other side of this conversation. We know what it is like to worry about a parent's safety while trying to respect their independence. We know the guilt, the questions that keep you up at night, the weight of wanting to get it right.

Use this guide at your own pace. Share it with siblings or family members who are part of the decision. And when you are ready to talk, whether that is tomorrow or six months from now, we are here.

With care,

Burien Best Care Home

What Is an Adult Family Home?

An adult family home is a licensed residential care option where up to eight residents live in a real house, in a real neighborhood, with round-the-clock caregivers. It is one of the best-kept secrets in senior care, and it may be exactly what your family is looking for.

	Adult Family Home	Assisted Living	Nursing Home
Setting	Real home, neighborhood	Apartment-style complex	Hospital-like facility
Residents	Up to 8	20 to 200+	Varies widely
Staff Ratio	1:3 to 1:4 (typical)	1:8 to 1:15 (typical)	1:6 to 1:10 (typical)
Meals	Home-cooked, family-style	Cafeteria or dining hall	Institutional cafeteria
Caregiver Consistency	Same team daily	Rotating shifts, large staff	Rotating shifts, large staff
Focus	Daily living, memory care	Independent living with support	Skilled medical nursing
Cost (WA avg/mo)	\$6,000 to \$15,000	\$6,000 to \$15,000	\$10,000 to \$20,000+

Key Advantages

- **Consistent caregivers.** Your parent sees the same faces every day, building trust and genuine relationships.
- **Family-style meals.** Food served together at the dining table, just like at home.
- **Individualized routines.** Care is shaped around your parent's preferences, not the other way around.
- **A real home environment.** No institutional lighting, no overhead intercoms. Just a house in a neighborhood.
- **Higher staff ratios.** With a maximum of eight residents, caregivers have more time and attention for each person.

What Daily Life Looks Like

Every adult family home is different, but here is what a typical day looks like for residents in our care. The goal is simple: maintain as much normalcy, dignity, and independence as possible.

Morning

Residents wake at their own pace. There is no alarm, no institutional schedule. Caregivers assist with bathing, dressing, grooming, and personal hygiene based on each person's needs and preferences. Breakfast is served together at the dining table with options for dietary needs and preferences. Medications are administered and documented.

Midday

Late morning and early afternoon bring activities tailored to residents' interests and abilities. This might include gentle exercise, music, puzzles, gardening, or simply sitting together in conversation. Visitors are welcome anytime; you do not need to schedule an appointment. Lunch is served family-style, with the same attention to nutrition and personal preference as every meal.

Afternoon

After lunch, residents who want rest can nap or enjoy quiet time. Others may have scheduled visits from physical therapists, occupational therapists, or other healthcare providers who come to the home. This is also a time for one-on-one engagement: reading aloud, looking through photo albums, crafting, or listening to music. Or simply sitting in the backyard enjoying the flower and vegetable garden.

Evening

Dinner is the final shared meal of the day, followed by quiet time, favorite TV shows, or gentle conversation. Caregivers assist with nighttime routines including changing into sleepwear, oral care, and getting settled in bed. Overnight staff remain on site to assist with anything that comes up during the night.

Medical and Health Support

- **Medication management.** Caregivers administer and track all medications on schedule.
- **Physician coordination.** The care team communicates regularly with your parent's doctors.
- **Health monitoring.** Vital signs, weight, appetite, mood, and behavior are tracked and documented.
- **Therapy visits.** Physical, occupational, and speech therapists can provide services in the home.
- **Meals.** Meals are served together at the table whenever possible, and in bedrooms when medical needs require it. Dietary restrictions, allergies, cultural preferences, and texture modifications are all accommodated.

How to Know It Is Time

There is rarely a single moment when it becomes clear that a parent needs more help. Instead, it tends to be a gradual accumulation of concerns. Here are some signs that families commonly notice.

Physical Safety Concerns

- Frequent falls or difficulty with balance
- Wandering or getting lost, even briefly
- Leaving the stove on or forgetting to lock doors
- Medication errors: missed doses, double doses, or confusion about prescriptions
- Unexplained bruises or injuries

Daily Functioning

- Difficulty bathing, dressing, or maintaining personal hygiene
- Trouble preparing meals or forgetting to eat
- Inability to manage household tasks (laundry, cleaning, bills)
- Difficulty getting in and out of bed or using the bathroom safely
- Noticeable weight loss or poor nutrition

Cognitive Changes

- Confusion about the time of day, day of the week, or the season
- Getting lost in familiar places
- Repeating the same questions or stories within minutes
- Difficulty following conversations or instructions
- Poor judgment about personal safety or finances

Caregiver Burnout

- You are physically and emotionally exhausted
- Your own health is declining from the stress of caregiving
- Your relationships with your spouse, children, or the person you are caring for are strained
- You cannot leave your parent alone for more than a short time
- You feel guilt, resentment, or hopelessness, even though you are doing your best

If several of these ring true, it may be time to start exploring options. That does not mean you need to make a decision today. It means the conversation is worth having.

Understanding Payment Options

Paying for long-term care is one of the most confusing parts of this process. Here is a plain-language overview of the most common options.

Private Pay

The most straightforward option. You pay the monthly rate directly to the home. In King County, adult family home costs typically range from \$6,000 to \$10,000 per month, depending on the level of care required. This is often comparable to or less than assisted living, and significantly less than skilled nursing.

Medicaid / COPES

Washington's Community Options Program Entry System (COPES) is the state Medicaid program that covers adult family home care for eligible residents. COPES is one of the most comprehensive long-term care Medicaid programs in the country. Eligibility is based on both income and assets, and the specific limits change annually. If you think your parent may qualify, contact your local DSHS Home and Community Services office or consult with an elder law attorney who can walk you through the application process. Many families are surprised to learn they qualify.

Long-Term Care Insurance

If your parent purchased a long-term care insurance policy years ago, it may cover adult family home care. Look for language in the policy that references "residential care," "adult family home," "custodial care," or "assisted living." Each policy is different, so contact the insurance company directly to understand coverage, daily or monthly benefit amounts, elimination periods, and required documentation.

VA Aid and Attendance

Veterans and surviving spouses of veterans may be eligible for the VA Aid and Attendance pension benefit, which can provide between \$1,500 and \$2,700 or more per month toward care costs. This is a significant benefit that many families do not know about. Eligibility depends on military service history, income, assets, and care needs. A VA-accredited claims agent or veterans service organization can help with the application.

Medicare

Important: Medicare does not cover long-term residential care. This is one of the most common misconceptions families encounter. Medicare covers short-term skilled nursing care after a qualifying hospital stay (typically up to 100 days), but it does not pay for ongoing room and board in an adult family home, assisted living facility, or nursing home.

Combining Payment Sources

Many families use a combination of these options. For example, a family might start with private pay while a Medicaid application is pending, or combine a long-term care insurance benefit with private funds to cover the full monthly cost. There is no single right approach. An elder law attorney or a senior care advisor can help you map out a plan that works for your family's specific situation.

Questions to Ask When Touring

When you visit a care home, bring this page with you. These questions will help you evaluate any home you tour, not just ours.

- What is the staff-to-resident ratio during the day? At night?
- How long have the caregivers worked here?
- Can I visit anytime without an appointment?
- How do you handle medical emergencies?
- What happens if my parent's needs increase over time?
- Do you accept Medicaid/COPES?
- How do you handle residents with dementia or memory loss?
- What are the meals like? Can I see a sample menu?
- How do you communicate with families about changes in condition?
- What does the transition and move-in process look like?
- Can my parent bring personal furniture and belongings?

Touring Tips

Visit at different times of day if you can. Pay attention to how residents and staff interact. Notice the smell, the lighting, and the noise level. Ask to see the kitchen and the bedrooms. Watch whether residents seem comfortable and engaged. Talk to family members of current residents if possible.

About Burien Best Care Home

Burien Best Care Home is a licensed adult family home located at 927 SW 132nd Street in Burien, Washington. We care for up to eight residents in a real home, in a real neighborhood, with a team that shows up every day because they genuinely love this work.

Our Services

- **Memory Care.** Specialized support for residents living with Alzheimer's disease, dementia, and other forms of cognitive decline.
- **Daily Living Assistance.** Help with bathing, dressing, grooming, mobility, medication management, and meals.
- **Parkinson's Disease Care.** Specialized support for residents with Parkinson's, including fall prevention, medication timing, exercise support, and daily living adaptations.
- **Respite Care.** Short-term stays so family caregivers can rest.
- **Post-Hospital Recovery.** 24/7 support after a hospital stay.
- **Hospice Care Coordination.** Comfort and support between hospice visits.

Our Team

Daniela Torkelson, Co-Owner, Provider and Resident Manager

Daniela has opened more than 40 adult family homes and currently oversees 11 facilities across King County. She is a former board member of the Adult Family Home Council for Washington State. Her depth of experience in licensing, compliance, and hands-on care is the foundation of everything we do.

Becca Pitts, Co-Owner and Real Estate Broker

Becca brings more than 15 years of experience as a licensed Washington real estate broker and holds the Seniors Real Estate Specialist (SRES) certification. Her understanding of senior housing, combined with her own personal experience navigating family care decisions, gives her a unique perspective on what families need during this transition.

Your Next Steps

Here are a few options based on where you are today.

Still Researching?

Take our free online evaluation to help you think through whether it might be time to explore care options.

burienbestcarehome.com/is-it-time

Ready to Talk?

Call us directly at 253.678.7089 or email info@burienbestcarehome.com. This is a real conversation, not a call center. Ask anything.

253.678.7089 | info@burienbestcarehome.com

Want to Visit?

Schedule a tour at our website. We will show you around, answer every question, and give you a sense of whether our home is the right fit for your family.

burienbestcarehome.com/contact

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